Ironically, VOC had to wage a battle within the company that was no less tough. His success with the company came in the face of fissures within. The marriage of convenience between business ambition and moderate Congress politics severely tested him. The dominant section of the company's directors decided that VOC was dispensable once he had established the company, raised the funds and acquired the steamers. Deceitful tricks were used to ease him out. From occupying an assistant secretary-ship enshrined in the Articles of Association he was demoted to the status of a paid employee as secretary and later an agent and superintendent. VOC stoically put up with these humiliations even as BI offered him bribes. Many of the company's directors developed cold feet when the colonial state turned the heat on them. With the district collector camped in Tuticorin the directors used coercion to ease out VOC.

This was VOC's finest hour. Refusing to budge, he offered to resign if, and only if, the company's directors could secure an assurance from the government that the company would not be harmed. VOC took the issue to the public, showing it as a political matter that it really was. He showed his true mettle by directly confronting Collector Wynch. Ultimately, when, in their final face-off, Wynch offered to withdraw security proceedings and legal action if only he would exile himself from Tuticorin, VOC did not flinch. Since he was under no illusion that SSNCo would be spared by the government, VOC refused to cut such a deal and paid a heavy price for his defiance.

VOC's rise to political prominence was brutally cut short by imprisonment. The legal struggle of appeal and memorializing brought his family to financial ruin—the public support that trickled in did little to avert it. Words fail to capture the plight of the young Meenakshi, burdened by two toddlers, following her husband from jail to jail. The privations and harshness of prison life—where VOC was made to work the oil mill like an ox—severely tested him. His younger brother, Meenakshisundaram lost his mind on hearing the prison sentence and maintaining him became VOC's lifelong responsibility. When he was still in prison, his father died broken-hearted; a firstborn VOC could neither attend the funeral nor perform the